

Week 4: Parler d'un événement passé (les souvenirs)

JSS3 French — First Term Lesson Note (Deep-Dive Edition)

Introduction

This week introduces two key past tenses in French — the **passé composé** and the **imparfait** — used together to recount memories and past events.

Le passé composé (Compound Past)

Used for **completed actions** at a specific point in the past. Formed with the present tense of *avoir* or *être* + the past participle.

J'ai visité Lagos l'année dernière. (I visited Lagos last year.)

Nous sommes allés au marché. (We went to the market.)

L'imparfait (Imperfect)

Used to describe **ongoing situations, habitual actions, or background description** in the past (what things were like, or what used to happen). Formed from the “nous” form of the present tense, minus -ons, plus imperfect endings (-ais, -ais, -ait, -ions, -iez, -aient).

Quand j'étais petit, j'habitais à Ibadan. (When I was young, I lived in Ibadan.)

Il faisait très chaud ce jour-là. (It was very hot that day.)

Passé composé vs. Imparfait

Passé composé	Imparfait
A specific, completed action	A background description or ongoing situation
“What happened”	“What things were like” / “what used to happen”
J'ai mangé du riz. (I ate rice.)	Je mangeais du riz chaque jour. (I used to eat rice every day.)

Exemple de souvenir

Quand j'étais en vacances, il faisait beau tous les jours. Un jour, je suis allé à la plage avec ma famille. Nous avons nagé et nous avons mangé du poisson grillé. C'était un très bon souvenir.

(When I was on holiday, the weather was nice every day. One day, I went to the beach with my family. We swam and ate grilled fish. It was a very good memory.)

Real-Life Application

This grammar allows students to write about a memorable holiday, a family event, or a special day — a common composition topic in French exams, combining background description (imparfait) with specific events (passé composé).

Evaluation Questions

- 1 Explain the difference between the passé composé and the imparfait.
- 2 Conjugate “visiter” in the passé composé for “je.”
- 3 Conjugate “être” in the imparfait for “nous.”
- 4 Translate into French: “When I was young, I lived in Kano.”
- 5 Translate into French: “We visited the museum last week.”
- 6 Choose the correct tense: “Il (faisait/a fait) chaud quand nous sommes arrivés.”
- 7 Write one sentence in the passé composé about something you did yesterday.
- 8 Write one sentence in the imparfait describing what your town was like when you were small.
- 9 Which auxiliary verb does “aller” use in the passé composé?
- 10 Write a short paragraph (4–5 sentences) about a childhood memory, using both tenses.

(Week 5 is Midterm Examination — revision of Units 1–4.)